
REVISER SERIES

RV04

Conditionals & the Subjunctive

The Concept Guide

Two questions. One master key. That is the whole topic.

Read this first, then climb: Easy → Medium → Hard.

This guide covers everything Easy and Medium ask. Hard adds two exam traps from the wild.

The Whole Topic in One Picture

A conditional is an if-sentence: **if this happens, that happens**. Students find the topic confusing because there seem to be too many types. There aren't. Every if-sentence you will ever meet answers just two questions:

Question 1: Is it REAL or IMAGINARY? (Could it actually happen, or are we only dreaming?)

Question 2: Is it about NOW / THE FUTURE, or about THE PAST?

Answer both, and the sentence builds itself. Meet Ravi. Watch one situation — Ravi and his exam — move through all four boxes:

REAL + ALWAYS TRUE → ZERO If + present, present — laws, facts, habits. Happens every single time. If Ravi revises daily, he stays sharp.	REAL + FUTURE → FIRST If + present, will + verb — a real possibility with a real result. If Ravi studies tonight, he will pass.
IMAGINARY + NOW → SECOND If + past, would + verb — dreaming about the present. It isn't true, so the verb steps back: study → studied. If Ravi studied, he would pass. (He doesn't study. We're imagining.)	IMAGINARY + PAST → THIRD If + had + V3, would have + V3 — dreaming about a past that never happened. Another step back: studied → had studied. If Ravi had studied, he would have passed. (He didn't. Too late now.)

MASTER KEY — One Step Back

The moment a sentence turns imaginary, its verb takes **one step back in time**. Present steps back to past (study → studied). Past steps back to past perfect (studied → had studied). That is why 'If Ravi **studied**' talks about *today*, not yesterday — the past form is not showing past time, it is showing imagination. This one key unlocks the second conditional, the third conditional, wish, if only, and as if. Whenever you are stuck, ask: is it imaginary? Then step back.

(V3 means the third form of a verb: go – went – **gone**. So V3 of 'study' is 'studied', V3 of 'take' is 'taken'.)

Part 1 · The Four Classic Conditionals

Rule 1 — Zero conditional — things that happen every time

In plain words: no imagination, no future. Just a fact.

If + present, present. Use it for laws of nature, rules and habits.

✗ If you heat ice, it will melt. (as a general fact)

✓ If you heat ice, it melts.

Rule 2 — First conditional — a real future

In plain words: this can genuinely happen, and here is what follows.

If + present, will + verb.

✓ If it rains tomorrow, the match will be cancelled.

Rule 3 — 'If' is allergic to 'will'

In plain words: the if-half never carries will, even when the meaning is future. Will stays in the result half.

One polite exception exists — you will meet it in Part 6.

✗ If you will work hard, you will succeed.

✓ If you work hard, you will succeed.

Rule 4 — Second conditional — dreaming about now

In plain words: it is not true today, but let's imagine. The verb steps back to the past form.

If + past, would + verb.

✓ If I had wings, I would skip the traffic altogether.

Rule 5 — In dreams, 'be' becomes 'were' — for everyone

In plain words: I were, he were, she were. Yes, really. 'Was' is the everyday slip exams love to punish.

✗ If I was you, I would accept the offer.

✓ If I were you, I would accept the offer.

Rule 6 — Third conditional — dreaming about the past

In plain words: the past already happened another way. We are imagining a rewind. Both halves step fully back.

If + had + V3, would have + V3.

✗ If she would have studied, she would have passed.

✓ If she had studied, she would have passed.

GOLD TRAP — 'would have' in the if-half

'If he would have called...' is the single most common conditional error in Indian English — so setters bait it constantly. **'Would have' appears once, in the result half, never in the if-half.** The if-half takes plain had + V3: If he **had called**, I would have answered.

Part 2 · Mixed Conditionals — Each Half Keeps Its Own Time

Real life crosses time zones. A choice made in the past can shape today; a habit you have today can explain something that happened last week. Don't panic — just give **each half its own correct time** and the sentence assembles itself.

Rule 7 — Past choice → present result

In plain words: something (didn't) happen back then, and we feel it today.

If + had + V3, would + verb (or would be + -ing). Look for **today / now / still** in the result half.

✓ If I had taken that job in 2020, I would be living in Mumbai today.

Rule 8 — Present nature → past result

In plain words: a permanent quality someone has explains a one-time past event.

If + past, would have + V3.

✓ If he weren't so stubborn, he would have apologised that evening.

GOLD TRAP — the time words decide everything

Setters plant anchors and wait for autopilot. **Today, now, still** in the result → would + verb. **Yesterday, last week, that evening** → would have + V3. Read the anchor before you answer — never complete the pattern from habit.

Part 3 · Inversion — The Same Sentences in Formal Dress

Formal English sometimes drops 'if' and moves the helper verb to the front. **Nothing about the meaning changes — only the outfit.** There are exactly three patterns, one per conditional:

Formal dress	Means exactly	Which conditional
Had I known...	If I had known...	Third (imaginary past)
Were she to resign...	If she were to resign...	Second (imaginary now/future)
Should you need help...	If you (happen to) need help...	First (real, formal chance)

Two small print rules for the formal dress:

Rule 9 — 'Were' pairs with to + verb; 'Should' pairs with the bare verb

In plain words: don't mix the outfits.

✗ Were the company go bankrupt... / Should you needed help...

✓ Were the company to go bankrupt... / Should you need help...

Rule 10 — In negatives, 'not' sits after the subject — never shortened

In plain words: no 'Hadn't I...' — that sounds like a question, which is exactly why setters use it.

✗ Hadn't I seen it myself, I would not have believed it.

✓ Had I not seen it myself, I would not have believed it.

GOLD TRAP — Were it not for vs Had it not been for

Both are correct English — the bait is **time**. Present result → **Were it not for** her, we **would be** lost. Past result → **Had it not been for** her, we **would have been** lost. Let the result half tell you which one to pick.

Part 4 · The Conditional Cousins

Four words that behave like 'if' but carry their own twist. One line each:

Rule 11 — Unless = if ... not

In plain words: unless already owns the 'not'. Adding another one flips your meaning upside down.

✗ Unless you don't hurry, you will miss the train.

✓ Unless you hurry, you will miss the train.

Rule 12 — In case = do it before, as a precaution

In plain words: you act first, so the problem never hurts you. Takes the simple present — never will.

✗ Carry an umbrella if it rains. (you'd start carrying it too late!)

✓ Carry an umbrella in case it rains.

Rule 13 — Provided that / as long as = strictly if

In plain words: permission with a condition attached. A deal, not a guess.

✓ You may quote from the archive provided that you cite every source.

Rule 14 — Wish / If only — three settings, all from the master key

In plain words: wishing is imagining, so the verb steps back. Which step depends on what you wish about.

Wish about **now** → one step back: I wish I **were** taller. Wish about **the past** → two steps: I wish I **had studied**.

Complaint about **someone else's habit** → would: I wish you **would stop** interrupting. And 'will' NEVER follows wish.

✗ I wish I can attend the wedding.

✓ I wish I could attend the wedding.

GOLD TRAP — but for / without = a conditional in disguise

But for your help, I would have failed = 'if it had not been for your help'. A tiny phrase hiding a full third conditional — so the result still needs **would have + V3**. Treating 'but for' as an innocent little preposition is the bait.

Part 5 · The Subjunctive — The Bossy-Verb Rule

Here is the part of the topic with the scariest name and the simplest rule. Some verbs are **bossy** — they order, demand or strongly advise: **demand, insist, suggest, recommend, order, direct, require, propose, move**. After a bossy verb + **that**, the next verb appears in its **plain dictionary form**. No -s. No tense. No matter who the subject is.

Rule 15 — Bossy verb + that + dictionary-form verb

In plain words: the -s disappears, even for he / she / it.

- ✗ The board insisted that he steps down.
- ✓ The board insisted that he step down.

Rule 16 — The passive version: be + V3

In plain words: when the action is done TO someone or something, the formula is that + be + V3.

- ✗ The court directed that the records are produced.
- ✓ The court directed that the records be produced.

Rule 17 — 'It is essential / important / imperative that...' is bossy too

In plain words: these phrases give orders without a bossy verb — same rule applies.

- ✗ It is essential that every player follows the rules.
- ✓ It is essential that every player follow the rules.

Rule 18 — As if / as though — imaginary comparisons take 'were'

In plain words: if the comparison is clearly not true, step back to were (the master key again).

If it might genuinely be true, normal tenses stay: 'It looks as if it is going to rain' — that could really happen.

- ✗ He behaves as though he was the owner.
- ✓ He behaves as though he were the owner.

Finally, some fixed phrases survive from old English exactly as they are. Memorise them; never 'correct' them: *God save the King · come what may · be that as it may · suffice it to say · far be it from me · so be it · long live the Republic.*

GOLD TRAP — the -s that looks right

'The panel recommended that the director **steps** aside' looks like perfect grammar — singular subject, singular verb. That is exactly why it is the most-set subjunctive trap in these exams. After a bossy verb, agreement switches OFF: **step**, plain, always.

Part 6 · When the Rules Bend

Every rule above has one pressure point where English itself bends. Setters hunt here — so know these five and nothing can surprise you.

If + will — the polite exception	When will means 'is willing to', it IS allowed after if: <i>If you will excuse me, I'll take this call.</i> Also for annoyed insistence: <i>If you will keep skipping class, you must accept the results.</i>
If + should — a formal long shot	<i>If you should see her, give her my regards.</i> Just a very formal 'if by chance'. Same as 'Should you see her'.
'If I was' — spoken only	Friends will say it; every exam marks it wrong. In the exam hall, imaginary 'be' is always were .
When = if, but only in the zero	For facts and habits the two swap freely: <i>When/If you heat ice, it melts.</i> No other conditional allows this.
Otherwise — the unspoken if	<i>Leave now; otherwise you will miss the train.</i> Otherwise simply means 'if you don't'.

One-Page Revision Table

Situation	Formula	Model sentence
Fact / habit (zero)	If + present, present	If you heat ice, it melts.
Real future (first)	If + present, will + verb	If it rains, we will stay in.
Dreaming about now (second)	If + past, would + verb	If I were rich, I would travel.
Rewinding the past (third)	If + had + V3, would have + V3	If she had left, she would have caught it.
Past choice → today (mixed)	If + had + V3, would + verb	If I had slept, I would be fresh now.
Present nature → past event (mixed)	If + past, would have + V3	If he weren't lazy, he would have finished.
Formal dress — third	Had + subject + V3, ...	Had I known, I would have come.
Formal dress — second	Were + subject + to + verb, ...	Were she to resign, we would struggle.
Formal dress — first	Should + subject + verb, ...	Should you need help, call us.
Unless	= if ... not (never add another 'not')	Unless you hurry, you will miss it.
In case	precaution + simple present	Take a map in case you get lost.
Wish about now	wish + past / were	I wish I were taller.
Wish about the past	wish + had + V3	I wish I had studied.
Complaint about a habit	wish + would + verb	I wish you would stop shouting.
Bossy verb + that	that + dictionary-form verb	She insisted that he apologise.
Bossy verb, passive	that + be + V3	He ordered that it be shut.
As if / as though (imaginary)	were / one step back	He talks as if he were the boss.

Spot Check — 10 sentences

Mark each sentence CORRECT or INCORRECT. No book, no guide, ninety seconds. Use the two questions and the master key.

1. If she will come early, we will start on time.
2. Had I known your number, I would have called.
3. I wish I was taller.
4. Unless you don't apologise, she won't talk to you.
5. The judge ordered that the fine be paid at once.
6. If he had left earlier, he would be home by now.
7. Were I to win the lottery, I will buy a farmhouse.
8. Take your ID in case the guard asks for it.
9. He orders us around as if he were the boss.
10. The panel suggested that she reconsiders her decision.

Q	Verdict	Why
1	INCORRECT	'If' is allergic to will: If she comes early.
2	CORRECT	Formal dress for the third conditional — Had + subject + V3.
3	INCORRECT	An imaginary wish steps back to were: I wish I were taller.
4	INCORRECT	Unless already owns the 'not'. Unless you apologise.
5	CORRECT	Bossy verb (ordered), passive: that + be + V3.
6	CORRECT	Mixed — past choice, present result ('by now').
7	INCORRECT	Were ... to = imaginary, so the result needs would, not will.
8	CORRECT	In case + simple present, acting before the problem.
9	CORRECT	Imaginary comparison after as if takes were.
10	INCORRECT	Bossy verb (suggested) switches agreement off: that she reconsider.

Readiness rule: 8 or more out of 10 → open RV04 Easy. Below 8 → reread the guide once, then retry the spot check.

Movement rule: Score 70%+ on a level before climbing to the next. Below 50% on any level? Come back to this guide before you retry. The guide covers everything Easy and Medium ask; Hard adds two exam traps from beyond these pages — meet them in the test, learn them on the review screen.

Next in the series: RV05 · Modifiers. — Sahil Sir